

Olympiad Test Paper — Social Science (Class 7)

Chapter 4: New Beginnings: Cities and States

Subject	Social Science (NCERT Class 7)
Chapter	4 — New Beginnings: Cities and States
Total Questions	60 (Multiple Choice, single correct)
Maximum Marks	240
Suggested Time	90 minutes

Marking scheme: +4 for each correct answer · -1 for each wrong answer · 0 if unattempted.

Instructions: Each question has four options (A), (B), (C), (D); exactly one is correct. This is history — read each stem carefully and reason from cause and effect, chronology, and the evidence described in the chapter. Watch the classic traps: confusing the FIRST Urbanisation (Harappan) with the SECOND (Ganga plains); assuming ALL mahaajanapadas were monarchies (Vajji and Malla were republics); thinking the Harappans used iron (they used copper and bronze); and treating the gana-sangha republics as full modern democracies. Do not write on this paper — mark answers on your answer sheet.

1. India's "First Urbanisation" refers to:

- (A) The sixteen mahaajanapadas
- (B) The Maurya Empire
- (C) The Harappan (Indus / Sindhu-Sarasvati) civilisation
- (D) The Chola kingdom

2. After the Harappan urban order broke down in the early 2nd millennium BCE, urban life in the Subcontinent was largely absent for about:

- (A) A hundred years
- (B) Three hundred years
- (C) Five thousand years
- (D) A thousand years

3. A historian argues that the Harappan collapse was not just a loss of buildings but a loss of "urban order." The BEST evidence for this claim is that after the collapse:

- (A) People built even larger cities elsewhere immediately
- (B) Iron tools suddenly appeared everywhere
- (C) People largely returned to simple village life, losing trade, writing and administration
- (D) The mahaajanapadas were formed within a few years

4. Which of these did NOT disappear when the Harappan urban order broke down — because it actually became widespread only LATER?

- (A) Planned drainage
- (C) Large fortified citadels

- (B) The Harappan writing system
- (D) The use of iron tools

5. The wave of city-building that began in the Ganga plains in the 1st millennium BCE is called the:

- (A) Vedic Urbanisation
- (C) Second Urbanisation

- (B) Third Urbanisation
- (D) Harappan revival

6. Place these in correct chronological order, earliest first: (i) the sixteen mahaajanapadas, (ii) the Harappan civilisation, (iii) the rise of janapadas, (iv) the first empires.

- (A) (ii) → (iii) → (i) → (iv)
- (C) (ii) → (i) → (iii) → (iv)

- (B) (i) → (ii) → (iii) → (iv)
- (D) (iii) → (ii) → (i) → (iv)

7. A historian studying the Second Urbanisation relies mainly on TWO kinds of sources. They are:

- (A) Archaeology and ancient literature
- (C) Television and the internet

- (B) Photographs and newspapers
- (D) Coins and the Constitution

8. Why can a historian be MOST confident that the Second Urbanisation really happened the way described?

- (A) Because one ancient poem says so
- (C) Because the Harappans wrote it down
- (D) Because both excavated city remains and ancient books agree about it

- (B) Because modern cities look old

9. The Sanskrit word "janapada" is made of jana ("people") + pada ("foot"). It therefore means:

- (A) A king's army
- (C) A silver coin

- (B) Where the people have set foot (settled)
- (D) A great empire

10. A janapada was best described as:

- (A) A wandering band with no fixed land
- (C) A territory settled by a clan and led by a rajaa
- (D) A single fortified gateway

- (B) A trading guild with no ruler

11. Why are janapadas regarded as among India's earliest states of this period?

- (A) Because they had no rulers at all
- (B) Because settled clans identified with their land, needed a rajaa to lead and protect it, and grew through trade
- (C) Because they were built by the Harappans
- (D) Because they used iron coins

12. By roughly which centuries BCE had janapadas merged into the larger mahaajanapadas?

- (A) The 2nd–1st centuries BCE
- (C) The 20th–19th centuries BCE

- (B) The 4th–3rd centuries CE
- (D) The 8th–7th centuries BCE

- 13.** The prefix "maha-" in "mahaajanapada" tells you the word means:
(A) A small village (B) A river crossing
(C) A royal coin (D) A great janapada
- 14.** The most frequently cited list names how many mahaajanapadas?
(A) 16 (B) 12
(C) 10 (D) 20
- 15.** The mahaajanapadas stretched from Gandhaara in the northwest to Anga in the east, and to Ashmaka in central India near which river?
(A) The Godavari (B) The Sindhu
(C) The Ganga (D) The Kaveri
- 16.** Why were SO MANY mahaajanapadas concentrated in the Ganga plains rather than elsewhere?
(A) The plains were cold and dry, which suited horses
(B) The plains had no rivers, so armies could march freely
(C) Fertile soil gave food surpluses, iron was nearby, and trade routes tied the region together
(D) The Harappans had already built their capitals there
- 17.** A typical mahaajanapada capital was protected by ramparts AND, just outside the walls, by a moat. A moat was:
(A) A tall stone watchtower (B) An open market square
(C) A deep, wide, water-filled ditch for defence (D) The king's private palace
- 18.** The gateways through a capital's walls were often kept deliberately narrow MAINLY so that:
(A) The city would look beautiful (B) Rainwater could drain out faster
(C) A few guards could control who and what entered or left
(D) Elephants could pass two at a time
- 19.** Rajagriha, Kaushambi and Varanasi were mahaajanapada capitals about 2,500 years ago and are still busy cities today. This remarkable continuity MOST strongly suggests that:
(A) Nothing about these places has ever changed
(B) The Harappans must have founded them (C) They were never actually fortified
(D) Their sites had lasting natural and strategic advantages
- 20.** Which set lists mahaajanapadas that were MONARCHIES?
(A) Vajji and Malla (B) Sabhaa and Samiti
(C) Cholas and Cheras (D) Magadha, Kosala and Avanti
- 21.** In each janapada, the rajaa was expected to take counsel from assemblies called the:

- (A) Uttaraapatha and Dakshinaapatha (B) varna and jaati
(C) Cholas and Pandyas (D) sabhaa and samiti

22. The words sabhaa and samiti first appear in:

- (A) The Vedas (B) Jain texts
(C) Buddhist texts (D) Tamil literature

23. Most members of the sabhaa or samiti were probably:

- (A) The elders of the clan (B) Foreign merchants
(C) Children of the rajaa (D) Soldiers of the army

24. "A good rajaa was not supposed to rule by himself or do whatever he liked." This statement BEST shows that even in monarchies:

- (A) The rajaa had no real power (B) The people elected the rajaa every year
(C) The rajaa was expected to take advice from the assemblies and ministers
(D) There was no army at all

25. In a monarchy, the position of rajaa was usually hereditary. This means the next rajaa was normally:

- (A) Chosen by the assembly through a vote (B) A foreign conqueror
(C) The richest merchant of the city (D) The son of the previous rajaa

26. Which of the following was NOT typically among a monarch's main duties as described in the chapter?

- (A) Selecting his successor by public election (B) Keeping law and order
(C) Collecting revenue (taxes) (D) Maintaining an army and fortifications

27. A mahaajanapada that was NOT a monarchy — where the assembly took major decisions — was called a:

- (A) gana or sangha (B) janapada
(C) varna (D) moat

28. Which TWO mahaajanapadas were ganas or sanghas ("early republics")?

- (A) Magadha and Kosala (B) Avanti and Anga
(C) Vajji (Vriji) and Malla (D) Gandhaara and Kuru

29. In a gana or sangha such as Vajji, the rajaa was:

- (A) Always the eldest son of the previous rajaa (B) Chosen by the Harappan priests
(C) Appointed by a foreign empire
(D) Selected by the assembly through discussion and, if needed, a vote

30. The single feature that MOST clearly makes Vajji and Malla "early republics" rather than monarchies is that:

- (A) They had stronger armies (B) They were larger in area
(C) Their assemblies took major decisions and even selected the ruler

(D) They used punch-marked coins

31. A classmate says, "Every mahaajanapada was ruled by an all-powerful king." The BEST correction is:

(A) "True — there were no exceptions." (B) "No — none of them had kings at all."

(C) "True — but only in the south."

(D) "No — at least Vajji and Malla were ganas/sanghas where the assembly decided major matters."

32. The ganas/sanghas are called "early republics," yet they were NOT modern democracies because:

(A) They had no assemblies at all (B) The rajaa inherited power by birth

(C) Decisions were taken jointly by the heads of leading families, not by every person

(D) Women alone took all decisions

33. The Harappans were experts in copper and bronze. The big new metal technology of the Second Urbanisation was:

(A) Iron

(B) Gold

(C) Silver

(D) Tin

34. A student writes, "The Harappan cities used iron tools and weapons." This is wrong because iron:

(A) Was never used in ancient India at all

(B) Was softer than the bronze the Harappans used

(C) Was used only for making coins

(D) Became widespread only later, by the late 2nd millennium BCE — a technology of the SECOND Urbanisation

35. Why was the spread of iron so important for the growth of cities and states?

(A) Iron was worshipped as sacred, so people gathered in cities

(B) Iron replaced the need for trade routes

(C) Iron axes and ploughs cleared forests and worked heavy soil, raising food surpluses that fed cities and armies

(D) Iron was used to print the first books

36. Iron tools also made armies stronger. The chapter links this to:

(A) The disappearance of all warfare

(B) The growth of bigger kingdoms through war and consolidation

(C) The end of farming

(D) The invention of writing

37. As trade grew, people needed something easier than barter. India's response was its first coins, which were:

(A) Silver punch-marked coins

(B) Copper paisa

(C) Gold dinars

(D) Cowrie shells

38. They are called "punch-marked" coins because:

- (A) They were used to punch holes in cloth
- (B) They were round like a fist
- (C) They were given as a reward in boxing
- (D) Symbols were punched (stamped) into the soft silver

39. The chapter says coins were invented MAINLY in order to:

- (A) Make trade easier than swapping goods by barter
- (B) Make people rich
- (C) Pay soldiers in gold only
- (D) Decorate temples

40. Why is barter clumsy compared with using coins?

- (A) Barter needs a bank
- (B) In barter you must find someone who has what you want AND wants what you have
- (C) Barter can only be done at night
- (D) Barter needs iron tools

41. Usually a mahaajanapada made its own coins, but:

- (A) No one ever used another region's coins
- (B) Only the Harappans were allowed to make coins
- (C) Coins from neighbouring regions were used and traded as well, even reaching abroad
- (D) Coins were banned outside the capital

42. The chapter describes Indian society organising itself through a TWO-fold system made up of:

- (A) sabhaa and samiti
- (B) jaati and varna
- (C) gana and sangha
- (D) Uttaraapatha and Dakshinaapatha

43. A jaati is best described as:

- (A) A water-filled defensive ditch
- (B) An occupational community whose skills and customs pass from parents to children
- (C) A great trade route
- (D) A silver coin

44. The varna system named four broad categories. Which varna was expected to defend society and the land and to engage in warfare if necessary?

- (A) Brahmins
- (B) Vaishyas
- (C) Shudras
- (D) Kshatriyas

45. According to the chapter, which varna was associated with preserving and spreading knowledge and performing rituals?

- (A) Kshatriyas
- (B) Vaishyas
- (C) Shudras
- (D) Brahmins

46. A student claims, "The varna-jaati system was always rigid and unchanging." The chapter corrects this by noting that:

(A) It never existed at all

(B) In the early period it was more flexible, and people could change occupations when circumstances demanded

(C) It applied only to the Harappans

(D) It became rigid the very day it began

47. Two famous routes connected India's regions for trade, pilgrimage and travel. The northern one was called the:

(A) Uttaraapatha

(B) Dakshinaapatha

(C) Rajagriha road

(D) Vindhya path

48. The Dakshinaapatha route started from Kaushambi (near today's Prayagraj) and then crossed which range to head south?

(A) The Vindhya Range

(B) The Aravallis

(C) The Himalayas

(D) The Western Ghats

49. The two great routes carried not only goods but also:

(A) Only soldiers, nothing else

(B) Pilgrims, armies, ideas and coins

(C) Only the rajaa's letters

(D) Only iron ore

50. Shishupalgarh, an eastern city with a neat square plan and strong fortifications, was the capital of which region?

(A) Magadha

(B) Kalinga

(C) Gandhara

(D) Avanti

51. Around 400 BCE, which THREE kingdoms emerged in the southern regions of the Subcontinent?

(A) Magadha, Kosala and Avanti

(B) Vajji, Malla and Anga

(C) Cholas, Cheras and Pandyas

(D) Kuru, Panchaala and Matsya

52. The south was drawn into trade with the rest of India largely because of its:

(A) Cold climate

(B) Valuable resources such as gems, gold and spices

(C) Lack of any rivers

(D) Distance from the sea

53. By about 300–200 BCE, the chapter says the Subcontinent had become:

(A) One vibrant, interconnected land, with goods and culture even reaching beyond India

(B) Completely empty of people

(C) Three separate islands

(D) Ruled entirely by the Harappans again

54. Around the same time that India became one interconnected land, the mahaajanapadas:

(A) Were just being founded for the first time

(B) Came to an end, making way for the great empires

(C) All became ganas/sanghas

(D) Moved to the Indus valley

55. Which sequence correctly traces a chain of cause and effect from the chapter?

(A) Coins invented → barter began → trade stopped

(B) Cities grew → forests appeared → iron disappeared

(C) Iron spread → more farmland cleared → food surplus → cities and states grew

(D) Empires formed → janapadas appeared → clans settled

56. Magadha, in today's Bihar, became one of the most powerful mahaajanapadas. From the chapter's logic, the BEST single reason is that it:

(A) Had no rivers, so it was easy to defend

(B) Sat on the fertile middle Ganga plain with food surpluses, river transport and nearby resources

(C) Was a gana/sangha that elected its rulers (D) Lay far to the south near the Pandyas

57. "The Second Urbanisation has never stopped — it continues right up to today." Which fact from the chapter BEST supports this?

(A) The Harappan cities are all still inhabited

(B) Most mahaajanapada capitals, like Varanasi, are still living cities about 2,500 years later

(C) Iron tools are no longer used

(D) Barter is still the main form of trade

58. A coin expert finds punch-marked coins of one mahaajanapada far away in another region. The BEST explanation from the chapter is that:

(A) The coins were fakes made yesterday

(B) Coins were traded between regions, so they travelled along the trade routes

(C) Every region used exactly the same single coin

(D) Coins could only be used in the city that made them

59. Compare a monarchy like Magadha with a gana/sangha like Vajji. The KEY difference is:

(A) In the monarchy one hereditary rajaa held ultimate power; in the republic the assembly took major decisions and chose the rajaa

(B) Monarchy had farming; the republic did not

(C) The monarchy had no army; the republic had a large one

(D) The republic used iron; the monarchy used bronze

60. What if iron metallurgy had NEVER spread in ancient India? Based on the chapter's reasoning, the MOST likely outcome is that:

(A) Cities would have grown even faster

(B) It would have been far harder to clear forests and plough heavy soil, so the Second Urbanisation would have been much weaker

(C) The Harappan civilisation would never have ended

(D) Coins would have been invented much sooner

End of question paper. Maximum marks: 240. Marking: +4 correct, -1 wrong, 0 unattempted.

Solutions — Social Science (Class 7), Chapter 4: New Beginnings: Cities and States

Marking: +4 correct, –1 wrong, 0 unattempted. Maximum marks **240**.

Answer Key

Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans
1	C	11	B	21	D	31	D	41	C	51	C
2	D	12	D	22	A	32	C	42	B	52	B
3	C	13	D	23	A	33	A	43	B	53	A
4	D	14	A	24	C	34	D	44	D	54	B
5	C	15	A	25	D	35	C	45	D	55	C
6	A	16	C	26	A	36	B	46	B	56	B
7	A	17	C	27	A	37	A	47	A	57	B
8	D	18	C	28	C	38	D	48	A	58	B
9	B	19	D	29	D	39	A	49	B	59	A
10	C	20	D	30	C	40	B	50	B	60	B

Answer-key distribution: A = 15, B = 15, C = 15, D = 15.

Worked Solutions

1. (C) India's First Urbanisation was the Harappan (Indus / Sindhu-Sarasvati) civilisation, with its planned cities, drains and writing. The mahaajanapadas, Maurya Empire and Cholas all came much later, in or after the SECOND Urbanisation — so they are time-period traps.

2. (D) After the Harappan order broke down in the early 2nd millennium BCE, urban life was largely absent for about a thousand years before cities returned in the Ganga plains. "Five thousand years" confuses the age of the whole story with the length of the gap.

3. (C) "Urban order" means trade, writing, sanitation and administration held together — not just buildings. The clinching evidence is that people slipped back into simple village life, losing those systems. Building larger cities (A) or forming mahaajanapadas (D) happened only much later; iron (B) belongs to the later Second Urbanisation.

4. (D) Drainage, writing and citadels were all features of the Harappan cities that were lost. Iron, however, was NOT a Harappan feature at all — the Harappans used copper and

bronze — and iron only became widespread later. So iron did not "disappear with" the Harappans; it had not yet arrived.

5. (C) The 1st-millennium-BCE wave of city-building in the Ganga plains is the Second Urbanisation (the Harappan being the First). "Third" and "Vedic Urbanisation" are invented labels; "Harappan revival" wrongly implies the old civilisation came back.

6. (A) Correct order: Harappan civilisation (ii) → janapadas form (iii) → these merge into the sixteen mahaajanapadas (i) → the first empires (iv). Option C wrongly puts the mahaajanapadas before the janapadas they grew out of.

7. (A) Because there are no written histories from that age, historians use two main sources: archaeology (digging up city remains) and ancient literature (books that name and describe the cities). Photographs, TV and the Constitution are all modern, so the other options are anachronisms.

8. (D) Confidence is highest when two independent kinds of evidence agree — the excavated city remains AND the ancient books. A single poem (A) or "looking old" (B) is weak; the Harappans (C) did not write about the Second Urbanisation.

9. (B) jana = "people", pada = "foot", so janapada means "where the people have set foot", i.e. where a clan has settled. The other options confuse it with an army, a coin or an empire.

10. (C) A janapada was a territory settled by a clan and led by a rajaa — settled, not wandering (A), and it did have a ruler, unlike the "no ruler" guild in B. A single gateway (D) is far too small.

11. (B) Janapadas count as early states because settled clans identified with their land, needed a rajaa to lead and protect them, and grew larger through trade — the marks of an organised state. They did have rulers (so A is wrong) and were not Harappan (C) or coin-based (D).

12. (D) Janapadas merged into mahaajanapadas by about the 8th–7th centuries BCE. The 2nd–1st centuries BCE (A) is the age of empires, the 20th–19th centuries BCE (C) is Harappan times, and "centuries CE" (B) is far too late.

13. (D) "maha-" means "great", so mahaajanapada = "great janapada" (a bigger state formed by merging). The other options ignore the word's parts entirely.

14. (A) The most frequently cited list names 16 mahaajanapadas. 10, 12 and 20 are near-miss number traps.

15. (A) Ashmaka lay in central India near the Godavari River. The Ganga and Sindhu belong to the north, and the Kaveri lies far to the south — geography traps.

16. (C) The Ganga plains were ideal because fertile soil produced food surpluses, iron sources were nearby, and trade routes linked the region — exactly the conditions big states need. The plains were warm and well-watered (not cold/dry, A; not riverless, B), and the Harappans had not built there (D).

17. (C) A moat is a deep, wide, water-filled ditch outside the walls, for defence. A watchtower (A), market (B) and palace (D) are all parts of a city but not a moat.

18. (C) Narrow gateways let a few guards control who and what entered or left (useful for defence and for taxing trade). Beauty (A), drainage (B) and elephant traffic (D) are not the chapter's reason.

19. (D) That cities like Rajagriha and Varanasi are still alive 2,500 years later suggests their sites had lasting natural and strategic advantages that keep attracting people. It does not mean nothing ever changed (A), that the Harappans founded them (B), or that they were unfortified (C).

20. (D) Magadha, Kosala and Avanti were monarchies. Vajji and Malla (A) were the republics; sabhaa/samiti (B) are assemblies, not states; Cholas and Cheras (C) were southern kingdoms.

21. (D) The advisory assemblies were the sabhaa and samiti. Uttaraapatha/Dakshinapatha (A) are trade routes, varna/jaati (B) is the social system, and the Cholas/Pandyas (C) are southern kingdoms.

22. (A) The words sabhaa and samiti first appear in the Vedas — the oldest texts — showing how ancient the idea of assemblies is. Buddhist, Jain and Tamil texts came later.

23. (A) The assemblies were made up mostly of the elders of the clan, whose experience commanded respect. Foreign merchants, royal children and soldiers were not their main members.

24. (C) That a good rajaa was "not supposed to rule by himself" shows even monarchs were expected to take advice from assemblies and ministers. It does not mean he had no power (A), that he was elected yearly (B — that fits republics, not monarchies), or that there was no army (D).

25. (D) "Hereditary" means the position passed by birth, so the next rajaa was normally the son of the previous one. Being chosen by an assembly (A) describes the gana/sangha republics, not a monarchy.

26. (A) A monarch's duties included revenue (taxes), law and order, and an army with fortifications. He did NOT select his successor by public election — succession was hereditary — so that is the odd one out.

27. (A) A non-monarchy where the assembly took major decisions was a gana or sangha. A janapada (B) is just a settled territory, a varna (C) is a social category, and a moat (D) is a ditch.

28. (C) Vajji (Vrijji) and Malla were the ganas/sanghas. Magadha, Kosala, Avanti, Anga, Gandhaara and Kuru in the other options were monarchies.

29. (D) In a gana/sangha the rajaa was selected by the assembly through discussion and, if needed, a vote — not inherited (A), not chosen by Harappan priests (B, an anachronism), and not appointed by a foreign empire (C).

30. (C) What makes Vajji and Malla republics is that their assemblies took major decisions and even selected the ruler — power lay with the group, not one hereditary king. Army size (A), area (B) and coin use (D) are not the defining feature.

31. (D) The correct reply is that NOT every mahaajanapada was a monarchy: at least Vajji and Malla were ganas/sanghas where the assembly decided. "No exceptions" (A) and "only in the south" (C) repeat the error; "none had kings" (B) overcorrects, since many WERE monarchies.

32. (C) They were "early republics" but not modern democracies because decisions were taken jointly by the heads of leading families, not by every individual. They DID have assemblies (so A is wrong) and the rajaa did NOT inherit power (B describes a monarchy).

33. (A) The big new metal of the Second Urbanisation was iron (the Harappans had mastered copper and bronze). Gold, silver and tin are distractors — silver was used for coins, but the transformative tool/weapon metal was iron.

34. (D) The student is wrong because iron became widespread only later, by the late 2nd millennium BCE, as a technology of the SECOND Urbanisation — after the Harappans. Iron WAS used in ancient India (so A is false) and it is harder, not softer, than bronze (B), and not used only for coins (C).

35. (C) Iron mattered because iron axes and ploughs cleared forests and turned heavy soil, creating the food surpluses that fed city populations and armies. It was not worshipped to draw crowds (A), did not replace trade routes (B), and was not used to print books (D).

36. (B) Stronger iron weapons made armies more powerful, fuelling wars and the growth of bigger kingdoms through consolidation. Warfare did not disappear (A), farming did not end (C), and writing is unrelated here (D).

37. (A) India's first coins were silver punch-marked coins. Copper paisa, gold dinars and cowrie shells are later or different forms of money — date/type traps.

38. (D) They are "punch-marked" because symbols were punched (stamped) into the soft silver. The fanciful options (cloth-punching, fist shape, boxing) miss the literal meaning.

39. (A) Coins were invented mainly to make trade easier than barter — a trusted standard-weight piece of metal anyone would accept. Making people rich (B), paying only in gold (C) or decorating temples (D) were not the purpose.

40. (B) Barter is clumsy because you must find someone who has what you want AND wants what you have (a "double coincidence of wants"). Barter needs no bank (A), is not limited to night (C), and does not require iron tools (D).

41. (C) Usually a mahaajanapada minted its own coins, but coins from neighbouring regions were used and traded too, even reaching abroad. So claims that no foreign coins were used (A), that only Harappans minted (B), or that coins were banned outside the capital (D) are wrong.

42. (B) Society organised itself through a two-fold system of jaati (occupational community) and varna (four broad categories). Sabhaa/samiti (A) are assemblies, gana/sangha (C) are types of state, and the routes (D) are for trade.

43. (B) A jaati is an occupational community whose specific skills and customs pass from parents to children. A defensive ditch (A) is a moat, a trade route (C) and a coin (D) are unrelated.

44. (D) The Kshatriyas were expected to defend society and the land and to wage war if necessary. Brahmins handled knowledge and ritual, Vaishyas trade/farming, Shudras service roles.

45. (D) The Brahmins were associated with preserving and spreading knowledge and performing rituals. Kshatriyas (A) were the warriors — the classic mix-up with Q44.

46. (B) The chapter corrects the "always rigid" idea by noting that early on the system was more flexible, and people could change occupations when circumstances (like a drought) demanded; it grew rigid only later. So "never existed" (A), "only Harappans" (C) and "rigid from day one" (D) are wrong.

47. (A) The northern route was the Uttaraapatha ("uttara" = north). The Dakshinaapatha (B) was the southern route; "Rajagriha road" and "Vindhya path" (C, D) are invented names.

48. (A) The Dakshinaapatha started near Kaushaambi/Prayagraj and crossed the Vindhya Range to head south. The Himalayas and Aravallis lie to the north/northwest, and the Western Ghats run along the southwest coast — geography traps.

- 49. (B)** Along the great routes moved not only goods but also pilgrims, armies, ideas and coins — which is how distant regions came to share a culture. The "only..." options (A, C, D) wrongly narrow this.
- 50. (B)** Shishupalgarh, with its square plan and strong fortifications, was the capital of Kalinga in the east. Magadha, Gandhaara and Avanti were elsewhere.
- 51. (C)** Around 400 BCE the Cholas, Cheras and Pandyas emerged in the south. Magadha/Kosala/Avanti (A) were northern monarchies, Vajji/Malla/Anga (B) were eastern/republican, and Kuru/Panchaala/Matsya (D) were northern janapadas.
- 52. (B)** The south was drawn into trade because of its valuable resources — gems, gold and spices — which the rest of India wanted. A cold climate (A), lack of rivers (C) or being far from the sea (D) would have discouraged trade, not encouraged it.
- 53. (A)** By about 300–200 BCE the Subcontinent had become one vibrant, interconnected land, with goods and culture even reaching beyond India. It was certainly not empty (B), split into islands (C), or back under the Harappans (D).
- 54. (B)** Around that same time the mahaajanapadas came to an end, making way for the great empires. They were not just being founded (A), did not all turn into republics (C), and did not relocate to the Indus (D).
- 55. (C)** The valid causal chain is: iron spread → more farmland cleared → food surplus → cities and states grew. Option A reverses coins and barter and ends with trade stopping; B has forests appearing and iron vanishing as cities grow (backwards); D reverses the whole timeline (empires before clans).
- 56. (B)** Magadha rose because it sat on the fertile middle Ganga plain, giving food surpluses, river transport and access to nearby resources (like iron) — geography and resources gave it the edge. It was not riverless (A) or a southern republic (C, D).
- 57. (B)** The proof that the Second Urbanisation never stopped is that most mahaajanapada capitals, such as Varanasi, are still living cities about 2,500 years later. The Harappan cities are NOT all still inhabited (A); iron and barter claims (C, D) are off-topic.
- 58. (B)** Coins of one mahaajanapada turning up far away is best explained by trade: coins travelled along the routes between regions. They were not fakes (A); regions did not all share one single coin (C); and coins clearly were used beyond their home city (so D is wrong).
- 59. (A)** The key difference: in a monarchy like Magadha, one hereditary rajaa held ultimate power; in a republic like Vajji, the assembly took major decisions and even chose the rajaa. Both had farming and armies, and the iron/bronze split (B, C, D) is invented.

60. (B) Without iron, it would have been far harder to clear the Ganga forests and plough the heavy soil, so far less surplus food — and the Second Urbanisation would have been much weaker. Cities would not have grown faster (A); the Harappan collapse is unrelated (C); and coins would not have come sooner (D).

Solutions complete: 60 / 60.